

U.S. Political Institutions

1. Constitutional Foundations and Political Culture

The US is a **federal constitutional republic** established by the **U.S. Constitution (1787)**.

Influenced by Enlightenment thinkers (e.g., **John Locke** and **Montesquieu**), it incorporates a system of:

- **separation of powers**
- **checks and balances**
- **representative democracy**.

Key Founding Figures:

- **George Washington** – first President, symbol of national unity.
- **James Madison** – the "Father of the Constitution".
- **Alexander Hamilton** – promoter of strong federal government.

The U.S. political culture values:

- **individual liberties**
 - **limited government**
 - **rule of law**
 - **free-market capitalism**
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2. US Federalism

The U.S. is a **federal state** comprising **50 states**, each with its own constitution, legislature, and judiciary.

Power is divided between:

- **Federal authority** (e.g., foreign policy, military, currency),
- **State governments** (e.g., education, public health),
- **Concurrent powers** (e.g., taxation, infrastructure).

This structure reflects a balance between unity and diversity, though tensions occasionally arise (e.g., over immigration, environmental regulation, or abortion laws).

3. The Separation of Powers and Checks and Balances

Inspired by **Montesquieu**, the U.S. system separates powers among three branches:

- **The legislative** (Congress): makes laws.
- **The executive** (the President): enforces laws.
- **The judicial** (the Supreme Court): interprets laws.

Each branch can **check** the other two:

- Congress can **override a presidential veto** and **impeach**.
 - The **President** can **veto legislation** and **appoint judges** (with Senate approval).
 - The **Supreme Court** can **declare laws or actions unconstitutional** (*judicial review*, established in *Marbury v. Madison*, 1803).
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4. The U.S. Congress – the legislative branch

A **bicameral legislature** composed of:

- **The House of Representatives / The lower house** (435 members): representation based on population; 2-year terms. *Current Speaker: Mike Johnson, Republican*
- **The Senate** (100 members): 2 per state, regardless of population; 6-year terms, staggered. *Key figures: Chuck Schumer (Democrat), Mitch McConnell (Republican)*

Congress passes federal laws, votes the budget, ratifies treaties (Senate), and confirms federal appointments.

5. The Presidency - the executive branch

The **President** is elected every four years via the **Electoral College**. He is both

- **head of state** and
- **head of government**

Presidential powers include:

- Signing or vetoing legislation
 - Appointing cabinet members and Supreme Court justices
 - Leading foreign policy and the armed forces
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6. The Supreme Court – the judicial branch

- is composed of **9 justices**, appointed for life.
- exercises **judicial review**, interpreting the Constitution and settling federal disputes.

Notable Justices:

- **John Roberts** (Chief Justice)
- **Clarence Thomas, Sonia Sotomayor, Amy Coney Barrett**, among others.

Key Decisions:

- *Brown v. Board of Education* (1954) – ended racial segregation in schools.
 - *Roe v. Wade* (1973, overturned in 2022) – recognized then rescinded a constitutional right to abortion.
 - *Obergefell v. Hodges* (2015) – legalized same-sex marriage.
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7. Political Parties and the electoral System

The U.S. follows a **two-party system**:

- **The Democratic Party**: Center-left. Supports social programs, civil rights, climate action.
 - Key figures: **Franklin D. Roosevelt, John F. Kennedy, Barack Obama**.
- **The Republican Party**: Center-right. Advocates for low taxes, strong defense, conservative values.
 - Key figures: **Ronald Reagan, George W. Bush, Donald Trump**.

Other minor parties exist (e.g., Libertarian, Green), but rarely win major offices due to the **first-past-the-post** (winner-take-all) system.

8. Elections and Political Participation

Presidential elections are held every 4 years. Voters do not directly choose the President but select **electors** in the **Electoral College**.

Other elections:

- **The Midterm elections** (Congressional, every 2 years)
- **State and local elections** (governors, mayors, etc.)

Voting is **decentralized**, and voter registration laws vary by state.

9. Additional Elements: Media, Lobbying, and Interest Groups

- The **media** plays a central role in shaping political discourse, with strong ideological divides (e.g., Fox News vs. MSNBC).
- **Lobbying** is legal and widespread, especially in Washington, D.C., where powerful interest groups influence policymaking.
- **Think tanks** and **advocacy organizations** (e.g., the NRA, ACLU, Heritage Foundation) are highly active.